at the Congress-led INDIA whose Lok Sabha gains flattered only to deceive, as the Maharashtra verdict shows. Nothing makes the Congress fail like success. After the Lok Sabha verdict, where it almost doubled its tally to 99 seats, the party was beset by a sense of entitlement and inexplicable complacency. Hence its ignominious defeat in Maharashtra, where its tally of 16 seats is its lowest ever in the state, and the earlier rout in Haryana, where it was widely expected to win.

Yet even as Modi and the BJP take a bow for snatching victories from the jaws of defeat thanks to Opposition complacency, these successes come with immense opportunities along with considerable challenges. Amitabh Kant, India's G20 sherpa and former CEO of NITI Aayog, believes that the PM must now hard-focus on economic growth. "These assembly wins have consolidated the prime minister's position in a very big way," he says. "It is a mandate for double-engine growth, for prosperity and for creating jobs." While GDP growth is estimated to be 6.5-7 per cent for this fiscal, Kant believes India should aim for a growth rate of 8-9 per cent to generate enough funds to meet the costs of the raft of new welfare schemes without cutting back on infrastructure spend and ensuring fiscal stability.

Perils of Freebie Politics

What the general election and the four assembly elections this year have shown is the negative trend of overrelying on freebies, especially direct cash transfers, to woo voters and win polls. In Maharashtra, the NDA partners, which fought under the banner of the Mahayuti, pushed through the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana soon after the Lok Sabha election, handing 23 million women from the economically weaker sections in the state a monthly dole of Rs 1,500. Simultaneously, the ruling alliance announced schemes for farmers and youth, which together are expected to cost the exchequer Rs 90,000 crore a year. This is the burden of success Mahayuti will have to bear as it begins a fresh term.

However, Robin Sharma, the campaign strategist for Eknath Shinde, believes the Ladki Bahin scheme was a game-changer, for the Mahayuti as well as for the women in the state, as money in their hands will bring about a social and economic change to their lives in a country where 90 per cent of the people have an annual income of less than Rs 1.6 lakh, or Rs 13,300 a month. Sharma's winning strategy for Shinde also involved highlighting a narrative of the Shiv Sena leader's humble beginnings and his natural empathy for the poor besides his accessibility compared to rival Sena leader Uddhav Thackeray's aloof demeanour.

The Congress's LS gains flattered only to deceive, as the Maharashtra results show. Nothing makes it fail like success



Sharma believes their welfare schemes neutralised Uddhav's ploy of dubbing Shinde *gaddar* (traitor) and helped him overtake the Thackeray scion in the CM popularity stakes.

Like Shinde in Maharashtra, Hemant Soren announced the Maiyya Samman Yojana in Jharkhand, which, too, entitled 5 million indigent women in the state to a monthly stipend of Rs 1,500. As soon as the BJP promised to increase the payout to Rs 2,100 in its manifesto, the INDIA bloc led by the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha leader topped it to Rs 2,500. It would cost cash-starved Jharkhand Rs 15,000 crore annually and come at the cost of development programmes. Even Prime Minister Narendra Modi, once dead against the idea of cash doles and mocking the Opposition for its 'revdi culture', eventually gave in. The BJP announced a slew of welfare schemes during the Lok Sabha election, which the PM advertised as "Modi ki guarantees" in his election campaign.

What made these welfare schemes indispensable for the NDA campaign was their usefulness in neutralising the INDIA bloc's efforts to highlight caste and class inequalities and calling for redistributive justice. Maharashtra was to be a crucible for the NDA's experiment, given the clash between Marathas and Other Backward Classes for a slice of the quota pie, the differences between Dalits demanding sub-categorisation within the Scheduled Caste quota and other SC communities opposing it, or the demand by the Dhangar (shepherd) community to be classified as tribals to avail reservations for Scheduled Tribes, which faced resistance from other tribal communities. DesignBoxed chief Naresh Arora, who as poll strategist for NCP chief Ajit Pawar successfully transformed his campaign, points out, "The Maharashtra election was expected to result in a regressive caste consolidation—one versus the other—but people voted above caste lines as was evident with the big Mahayuti win that saw support across caste groups and regions. Voters pushed for development—that is a progressive step